

Settling the nervous system

Regulation basics — simple, evidence-based ways to help the body steady so the gut can settle.

The gut is exquisitely sensitive to the body's stress response. When the nervous system is activated, digestion changes and gut sensations sharpen. Learning to **settle** the system is one of the most useful skills for living with a DGBI.

Activated vs settled

An **activated** system can feel like a racing heart, shallow breathing, tension, restlessness, and a gut that is churning or clenched. A **settled** system feels slower and softer — the breath deepens, muscles release, and the gut has room to work.

Practical tools

- **Extended exhale.** Breathe in for about 4, out for about 6–8. The long out-breath is the body's brake pedal.
- **Physiological sigh.** Two short inhales through the nose, then one long slow exhale — repeat a few times to down-shift quickly.
- **Grounding.** Feel your feet, name five things you can see, hold something textured — this anchors you in the present.
- **Movement & rhythm.** A gentle walk, stretching, or anything rhythmic helps discharge activation.
- **Routine.** Regular sleep, meals and pauses give the nervous system predictability, which it reads as safety.

Little and often beats long and rare

You're building capacity, like fitness. A minute of regulation several times a day does more than one long session. Practise when you're calm, so the skill is there when you need it.

Pair these with the **C³ Loop™** — a three-minute daily reset of **Centre, Clarify, Choose** — to keep the system steady between harder moments.

This sheet is general information — not a diagnosis or a substitute for medical care. EF Health psychological support works alongside your medical team, never instead of it. If your symptoms are new, severe, or changing, please speak with your GP or specialist.

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